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Reflection on Web Scraping and Accountability

I think the current system for holding short-term rental hosts accountable in San Francisco is somewhat effective but overall still has a lot of gaps. While hosts are required to register and platforms like Airbnb are supposed to display policy numbers, there is still a heavy reliance on outside parties to check if everything is actually being followed. This creates a system where accountability is not fully enforced unless someone actively goes looking for violations. In my opinion, this makes the system somewhat inadequate because it depends too much on third parties rather than having stronger built-in enforcement. One possible improvement would be requiring Airbnb to automatically verify policy numbers with the city before allowing a listing to go live. This would align with ideas from the SWE Code of Ethics, especially around responsibility and ensuring systems are designed to prevent harm rather than just reacting after problems occur.

One important factor to consider when discussing the legality of web scraping is whether the data being scraped is publicly accessible or behind some type of restriction. Even if data is technically public, scraping can still raise legal concerns if it violates a website's terms of service or bypasses security measures. The Computer Fraud and Abuse Act makes this even more

complicated because accessing data in certain ways could be interpreted as unauthorized access. I think this matters because it shows that legality is not just about whether information is visible, but also about how it is collected and used.

When deciding whether web scraping is ethical, there are a few guidelines that should be considered. First, there should be a clear purpose that benefits society, such as improving transparency or identifying harmful practices. Scraping just for personal gain or without a meaningful reason can be harmful. Second, privacy should always be respected, even if the data is publicly available. Just because information is online does not mean people expect it to be collected, analyzed, and reused at a large scale. Overall, web scraping can be a powerful tool, but it needs to be used responsibly with clear ethical boundaries.